to an Indian nationalist movement that agitated for independence from the British Empire. From its inception, Pakistan's identity was molded partly in opposition to India.[3] The basis for partition from India was the two-nation theory, which argued Muslims and Hindus constituted two nations that could never live together. The man most responsible for the country's birth was Mohammad Ali Jinnah, who is officially known in Pakistan as Quaid-e-Azam [Great Leader] and Baba-e-Qaum [Father of the Nation]. As head of the Muslim League in British-controlled India, Jinnah called for the establishment of a new Muslim nation concomitant with Britain's granting of independence to Hindu-dominated India. Jinnah and the Muslim League appealed to religious sentiment and employed the mobilizing language of Islam to facilitate the transition from a Muslim community living in British India to a Pakistani nation.[4]

Islam was employed as a means to ensure Pakistan came into existence, but debates over what role it should play in governing the country continue to this day. The use of Muslim identity to mobilize support for Pakistan led some to interpret this to mean Pakistan was founded as an Islamic state. Others contended the intention was limited to creating a country in which Muslims could lead secure lives free from Hindu dominance. According to Farzana Shaikh, who explored this issue in *Making Sense of Pakistan*, the 'vexed relationship' between Islam and nationalism has proved to be the 'single greatest source of ideological uncertainty in Pakistan.'[5] However, as she notes, Islam and nationalism are not discrete concepts. There is significant interplay among the various ideas of Pakistan: as a cultural haven; a homeland; an Islamic state; or an Islamic vanguard.[6]

Although debates over the role of Islam in the nation continue, it is safe to say the majority of Pakistanis have no desire to live in a theocracy. No religious party has ever come close to winning power at the national level, though Islamist parties 'consistently punch above their electoral weight' in terms of influence on national politics.[7] This stems largely from effective mobilization of their political bases as well as their employment of Islamic identity and wedge issues to pressure successive national governments into adopting aspects of their platform.[8] The Islamist parties' success also has roots in the course charted by Pakistan's rulers from its inception, one that was intrinsically tied to the issue of how to build one nation out of the disparate ethno-linguistic groups inhabiting it.